coaching. It couldn't have been more different from Sunday League. All the time I was with Ridgeway, I'd tried to imagine what it would be like and this was it: soccer was my job. I didn't have to do anything else.

I had two years to get ready for moving up to Manchester permanently. I'd had plenty of trips away with Ridgeway and representative sides when I was younger, too. But neither of those things made it any easier when it came time to leave home. Of course I was excited and it was never a case of having second thoughts but, even so, it wasn't easy to go. I was very nervous about what lay ahead of me. Mum and Dad said they'd be up every weekend to see me play, that they wouldn't miss a game, and I knew they'd keep to their word. Promises count for a lot in the life of a family. Nowadays, I wouldn't dare forget if I've told Brooklyn I'll get him something or do something for him: he'll remember even if I don't.

Being away for a week or a month is completely different to moving away from home for good: I was fifteen and a half. Where you end up staying in digs as a young player is so important, especially when you think about how much else you're going to have to find out about when you begin your working life, full-time, at a big club like Man United. Every club has a list of landladies they use and I've often wondered whether it's just chance who you end up with, or whether they try to fix boys up in places they know will be right for them. Looking back, I think I was pretty lucky although it was a while before I found myself somewhere that really felt like home.

My first digs were with a Scottish couple who lived in Bury New Road, next to the fire station. They were lovely people and very good to me and the other boys who were there. Being young lads away from home for the first time, there was a bit of prankish behavior that went on: late-night kitchen raids for snacks, that kind of thing. We had fun. When I left, it was because of a strange incident that was completely out of keeping with the rest of my time there. I'd gone down the road to the gas station to get some chocolate and forgotten my key. I got back and knocked on the door, which was answered by the husband, Pete. He asked me where my key was and, when I said I thought I'd left it upstairs, he gave me a little clip round the ear. I wasn't too happy about it and I remember, that evening, my dad was on the phone to him. I was on the other side of the room and I could hear Dad shouting. That was the end of that arrangement.

I moved down to a place on Lower Broughton Road, with a landlady named Eve Cody. I got on really well with her son, Johnny, and was very happy there for almost a year. I shared a room with John O'Kane, who I